

Judge bars Trump use of 1798 law to deport

Planes with immigrants ordered to turn around; president cited ‘invasion’

BY TOBI RAJI, MARIANNE LEVINE AND MARIA SACCHETTI

A federal judge barred President Donald Trump on Saturday from using a wartime powers act to deport alleged Venezuelan gang members without a hearing, ordering the administration to turn around any planes that had already taken off after the Alien Enemies Act went into effect.

Trump signed a proclamation Friday to deploy the Alien Enemies Act for the first time since World War II to swiftly remove Venezuelans allegedly involved in the transnational gang known as Tren de Aragua. The act has been used only three times to bar citizens of hostile enemy governments from the United States, and only during a declared war.

U.S. District Judge James Boasberg, the chief judge in the District of Columbia, quickly blocked officials from deporting Venezuelans under the proclamation after civil rights groups filed a challenge earlier Saturday. As he issued his ruling, the judge said he heard that “flights are actively departing” and ordered the Trump administration to immediately halt the removals and return to the United States any flights that are in the air.

He said the immigrants clearly face irreparable harm, “given that these folks will be deported and many or the vast majority to prisons in other countries or sent back to Venezuela, where they face persecution, or worse.”

“This is something that you need to make sure is complied with immediately,” he told the

SEE TRUMP ON A6



NANNA HEITMANN/MAGNUM PHOTOS/FOR THE WASHINGTON POST

Even as Russia’s shadow deepens, Belarus maintains its balancing act

BY FRANCESCA EBEL IN NOVAYA GUTA, BELARUS

Teens work with rappelling gear at a training center in Brest that focuses on Belarus’s Soviet history. Although President Alexander Lukashenko has close ties to Russia, he has also sought to preserve his country’s independence.

Three years after Russia used Belarus as a launching pad for its brutal invasion of Ukraine, the border here between Belarus and Ukraine is eerily quiet.

Gone are the days when the highway at this crossing was a bustling conduit between the port of St. Petersburg on the Baltic Sea and the port of Odessa on the Black Sea. Now the crossing is used only for exchanges of prisoners of war and dead soldiers. Rows of dragon teeth puncture the surrounding fields and roads, and the way to Ukraine is barricaded and desolate.

Belarus lost a lot in severing its relationship with Ukraine — the West doubled down on sanctions after Minsk allowed Russian troops to use its territory as a staging ground. And Belarus is more than ever seen as a proxy

for Moscow, with President Alexander Lukashenko even acquiescing to hosting Russian tactical nuclear weapons, including Moscow’s latest, the Oreshnik hypersonic ballistic missile.

While Lukashenko has expressed “no regrets” about Belarus’s role in the conflict, his public statements belie a more complex picture of a country walking a delicate tightrope between its Soviet past — and an aggressive eastern neighbor — and its aspirations for renewed engagement with the European Union.

After Russia helped Lukashenko weather protests against his rule, he leaned even more into his country’s pre-independence Soviet identity for everything from language to education. At the same time, however, he made overtures to the West to present

SEE BELARUS ON A14

Warning Iran, U.S. strikes at Houthis

WARSHIPS, JETS HIT MILITANTS IN YEMEN

Trump tells Tehran to cease its support

BY ALEX HORTON, DAN LAMOTHE, MISSY RYAN AND MUSTAFA SALIM

U.S. forces launched a “decisive and powerful” attack on Houthi militants in Yemen, President Donald Trump said Saturday, an escalation against the group targeting maritime traffic and American troops in the Red Sea that doubled as a sharp warning to Iran, its major backer.

U.S. warships and jets launched attacks across Yemen, targeting radars, air-defense sites and drone launch points, a defense official said, speaking on the condition of anonymity because of the sensitivity of the issue. The operation marks the beginning of a renewed campaign to degrade Houthi military capabilities, the official added.

“The Houthi attack on American vessels will not be tolerated,” Trump said in a post on social media. “We will use overwhelming lethal force until we have achieved our objective.”

In his statement, Trump directly addressed the militants’ sponsors in Iran, who are believed to provide them with weapons and funding: “Support for the Houthi terrorists must end IMMEDIATELY!” he said, warning the government in Tehran that “America will hold you fully accountable and, we won’t be nice about it!”

Trump in recent days has appealed to Iran’s Supreme Leader Ali Khamenei in hopes of

SEE YEMEN ON A13

Trump moves to gut agencies, repeal Biden’s energy record

BY BRIANNA TUCKER AND EMILY DAVIES

President Donald Trump has signed an executive order seeking to eliminate several additional federal agencies, including one that oversees the federally funded media outlet Voice of America (VOA), testing the limits of his authoritative power as he seeks to shrink the size and scope of the federal bureaucracy.

One order signed Friday calls for the agencies — some of which are focused on minority business enterprises, museum and library services, and homelessness prevention — to “be eliminated to the maximum extent consistent with applicable law.”

A second executive order revoked 19 executive actions signed by President Joe Biden that promoted clean energy and environmental goals. The order terminates proclamations of national monuments created by Biden and ends the use of the Defense Production Act to expand the U.S. manufacturing of clean energy technology, such as for electric

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Rehired, not interested: Some fired feds may take a pass. **A9**

DEI purge at Arlington: Cemetery removes links to grave listings. **C1**



FILIPPO MONTEFORTE/AFP/GETTY IMAGES

A cardinal at the Vatican in 2023. Pope Francis has been hospitalized for just more than a month.

The not-so-quiet talk on the next pope

Candidates are emerging even as Francis recovers from health crises

BY ANTHONY FAIOLA AND STEFANO PITRELLI

VATICAN CITY — Candidates include cardinals from Asia and Africa, though whispers in the hallways of the Holy See also speak of a return to the well of Europe. In a church where hard-line traditionalists have feuded with Pope Francis, some see a need for a peace-

maker. Others believe a Vatican in financial crisis requires first and foremost a fundraiser.

Vatican officials warn that it’s disrespectful to discuss the conclave that will elect Francis’s successor while the 88-year-old pontiff is still in his Rome hospital suite recovering from a series of health crises. But that hasn’t stopped the talk, or what at times has ap-

peared to be open campaigning, in violation of canon law.

“The pope is still alive,” said Alberto Melloni, a Rome-based Vatican watcher. “But it feels like the conclave has already begun.”

Until Francis was hospitalized last month, the process of choosing his replacement was seen as potentially years away

SEE CONCLAVE ON A11

Storms kill 28 in central U.S. as risk of tornadoes peaks

System expected to bring threat of severe weather Sunday to Mid-Atlantic

BY BEN NOLL, GAYA GUPTA, HOLLY BAILEY AND VICTORIA CRAW

Local authorities said at least 28 people were killed in weather-related mayhem that raked the central United States on Friday and Saturday, demolishing homes, fanning wildfires and wrecking motorists’ vehicles.

In Missouri, at least 12 deaths were reported Saturday afternoon after more than a dozen tornadoes ripped across the state, according to the governor. Arkansas authorities reported three deaths and 29 injuries after a storm moved through their state.

Eight people were killed in Kansas after the weather front brought high winds and a dust storm Friday afternoon, lowering visibility and causing a pile-up involving dozens of vehicles, the state’s highway patrol said in a news release Saturday afternoon. One person died in a car crash after driving in wildfire smoke conditions in Oklahoma, according to the governor. And in the Texas panhandle, four people died in car crashes caused

by strong winds and dust storms, according to state officials.

“We’ve had significant wind storms in the past, but nothing of this” severity, said Sgt. Cindy Barkley of the Texas Department of Public Safety. “It was horrible.” She added that when she went to the crash scenes, there were times she could barely see past the hood of her car.

A tornado outbreak was expected to continue throughout Saturday night, with the highest risk across several states in the Deep South.

A total of 49 tornadoes had been reported in the central and southern United States since early Friday, with several still active from eastern Mississippi to southern Tennessee as of Saturday evening. Jarring video out of Walthall County, Mississippi, showed how a tornado reduced homes to rubble and hewed large swaths of trees caught in its path.

A rare high risk (Level 5 out of 5) for severe thunderstorms that covered Mississippi and Alabama for much of Saturday transitioned to a moderate risk (Level 4 out of 5), covering Alabama, western Georgia and the Florida Panhandle into early Sunday.

Fires also broke out across Oklahoma and Texas starting Friday, sparked by low humidity and powerful winds that overturned tractor-trailers. Hundreds of blazes erupted across

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